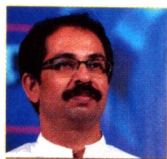


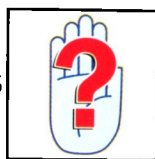
SOF THE STATES. THE MESSAGE FROM GUJARAT IS: GROW LOCAL, GO NATIONAL

MAHARASHTRA



U. THACKERAY
SHIV SENA

VS



CONGRESS

The Congress's infighting and NCP's ambivalence may just make the Shiv Sena scion's way to the top easier.

ASSAM



TARUN GOGOI
CONGRESS

VS



BJP

All issues plaguing the north-eastern state fit in with BJP's agenda, but the party is unable to make any inroads.

HARYANA



B.S. HOODA
CONGRESS

VS



VS



O.P. CHAUTALA
INLD

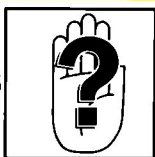
The Congress has a homegrown leadership, but BJP will have to depend on unpredictable allies like INLD.

RAJASTHAN



VASUNDHARA
RAJE BJP

VS



CONGRESS

After his mismanagement in the last regime, Ashok Gehlot was eased out but there is no replacement to fight Raje.

DELHI



SHEILA DIKSHIT
CONGRESS

VS



BJP

After two stints in power, Dikshit will face the anti-incumbency factor but BJP is yet to name her main rival.

KERALA



O. CHANDY
CONGRESS

VS



VS



V.S. ACHUTHANANDAN
CPI(M)

Despite a strong following, BJP is yet to make a debut in the assembly or in Parliament. Long road ahead.

UTTARAKHAND



B.C. KHANDURI
BJP

VS



CONGRESS

With its best bet N.D. Tiwari opting to retire from active politics, the Congress needs a heavyweight to counter BJP.

ANDHRA PRADESH



CHANDRABABU
NAIDU TDP

VS



RAJASEKHARA
REDDY CONGRESS

Once an ally, Naidu is now estranged from BJP. Unless the party finds a strong leader, it will be tied to his apronstrings.

PUNJAB



P.S. BADAL
SAD

VS



VS



R.K. BHATTAL
CONGRESS

The Akali Dal has been a strong ally, but in a bi-partisan set up, it would help to develop a strong local leadership.

from visiting their constituencies. While BJP drafted its national stars for electioneering, the Congress could not trust anyone outside the Family. Most Union ministers had to satisfy themselves by addressing press conferences or small rallies. Even powerful chief ministers like Maharashtra's Vilasrao Deshmukh and Andhra Pradesh's Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy couldn't draw a respectable crowd.

What, then, can Indian politics learn from the Modi model of leadership? Can it work outside Gujarat? True, certain characteristics of Planet Modi have to be seen in the specific context of Gujarat. The Modi method,

though, brings out the oldest truth in politics: true leaders not only make all the difference, they even make the familiar ideology look different. And even among them, some make history, and history makes use of others. Modi refused to be moulded by a bad piece of history. That was his biggest leadership challenge—and he won.

The political arena will be a lot more exciting if it can emulate the best of Modi. A politician should strike the right balance between conviction, courage and innovation. He should have the communication skills to take these qualities to the people. The most effective leaders are those who can have an inti-

mate conversation with the people. Think of the original Mrs G. Such leaders redeem ideologies from abstractions. That is why Hindutva, no matter how masculine it is in Modi's words, is accessible, immediate and worth voting for. That is why the dispossession of the Dalit is inseparable from the supremacy of Mayawati. That is why, in another age, MGR and NTR were acronyms for mass adoration. The ideological demagogue on the stump should be a marketeer of good governance as well. For the sake of Indian politics, let there be more of Modi and Maya. They reduce the distance between the leader and the people. ■